part of his empire in the North (Bairat, Delhi, Ahraura, Ratanpurwa, and Sasaram), in the heartland of Central India (Gujjara and Rupnath), and in the Deccan where, in fact, the most frequent articulation of his persona as a royal Buddhist convert came to be set down—this message being engraved in ten separate places there.[21] Reading it would have left no one in doubt that the emperor was now an ardent advocate of Buddhism. He declared at the outset that he had become a Sakya, meaning a Buddhist (after the Buddha's well-known title 'Sakyamuni'). Elsewhere, in some versions of this message, he described himself as a lay follower ('upasake') of the Buddhist faith.

Ashoka had become a lay worshipper, he stated, some two and a half years earlier, although his initial formal adherence to the new faith was not enough, in his assessment, to make him sufficiently zealous. This seems to mean that Ashoka did not at first feel great interest in the morality and faith of the religion. It may also mean that, as with other laypersons, a great deal within Buddhist discourses and 'laws' had not been communicated to him. From an oft-recounted story about Anathapindaka, the rich banker who generously set up the Jetavana monastery at Sravasti for the Buddha, we learn that this kind of reticence with laypersons was fairly common. During an illness, Anathapindaka called Sariputra, the Buddha's disciple, who, when comforting him, expounded a sermon on a subject that the ill banker was not aware of—disgust towards sense-objects, we are told. At the end of it the banker was in tears and told Sariputra that while he had revered the Buddha a long time, this was the first time he had heard such a religious discourse. Sariputra is said to have told him that such expositions were not explained to the laity but only to the religious order.[22] The same hesitation to expound a powerful doctrine immediately upon the king's conversion may have been considered desirable, the assumption probably being that a graduated process was in the longer term more effective towards ensuring